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PRINT EDITION

SPORTS

No. 04
SATURDAY, OCTOBER 31, 2026

Dallas ends two perfect starts.

FROM	my Agent
STAMP	Every claim checked.
EDITION	Sports, every day

The Mavericks beat Houston 116-111 on the NBA Cup's opening night, two days after handing Oklahoma City its first loss. Memphis is the NBA's last unbeaten team, and Minnesota takes the NFL's to Detroit on Sunday.

As of Oct. 31, 2026 · About a 4-minute read

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THE LEAD · NBA

Dallas, *spoiler twice in three nights.*

Dallas beat Houston 116–111 at American Airlines Center on Friday, Oct. 30, ending the Rockets' 5–0 start. Kyrie Irving scored 35 points with nine assists for the Mavericks; Kevin Durant led Houston with 28. It was the NBA Cup's opening night, so the final also counts in West Group A, which the two teams share with Denver, Phoenix and Utah.

Wikipedia (Mavericks season) · Wikipedia (Rockets season) · Wikipedia (2026 NBA Cup)

On the same floor on Wednesday, Oct. 28, the Mavericks beat Oklahoma City 120–96 for the Thunder's first loss, with Cooper Flagg scoring 26. Dallas, beaten at Houston in its opener and at home by San Antonio, is now 4–2.

Wikipedia (Mavericks season) · Wikipedia (Thunder season)

That leaves Memphis, at 5–0, as the league's only unbeaten team in Wikipedia's season standings, and its first 5–0 start since 2014–15. Brooklyn and Sacramento, both 0–5, have yet to win; the Nets lost their Cup opener to Detroit 110–94.

Wikipedia (2026-27 NBA season) · Wikipedia (Grizzlies season) · Wikipedia (2026 NBA Cup)

AGENT ANALYSIS
THE READ · NBA CUP

A loss that counts twice.

Friday's 10 Cup games count in the regular-season standings and in five-team groups where each team plays only four group games, two at home and two away, on Tuesdays and Fridays through Nov. 27. So Houston's loss weighs more in the Cup than in the 82-game table: the Rockets have three group games left before the quarterfinals on Dec. 4–5. Six games can't separate a hot start from a strong team, and Dallas has itself lost twice. What the week has shown is narrower: two of the West's unbeaten starts ended in the same building, against the same opponent.

Wikipedia (2026 NBA Cup) · Wikipedia (2026–27 NBA season) · Wikipedia (Mavericks season) · Wikipedia (Rockets season) · Wikipedia (Thunder season)

NFL · SUNDAY

The last unbeaten team *visits Detroit*.

Minnesota, 6–0 and the NFL's last unbeaten team, plays at Detroit on Sunday, Nov. 1, at 1 p.m. ET on Fox. It is the Vikings' first 6–0 start since 2009, and it has been built on defence: no opponent has scored more than 22 points against them, and their season record says they were the first team since the 1934 Lions to start 4–0 despite going without an offensive touchdown in two of those games.

Wikipedia (Vikings season) · Wikipedia (Lions season)

The division around them is crowded. Chicago is 5–2, Detroit 4–2 and Green Bay 5–3 after Thursday's win over Carolina, so every NFC North team has a winning record. The Lions, coming off a 20–17 home win over the Packers on Oct. 25, can pull within a game of Minnesota in the loss column.

Wikipedia (Bears season) · Wikipedia (Packers season) · Wikipedia (Lions season)

Elsewhere on Sunday, Baltimore, 4–3, plays at Buffalo at 1 p.m. ET. The Ravens' season record says Lamar Jackson was ruled out of the last three games, citing a left ankle sprain for the first two, and they went 1–2 without him. This issue found no permitted source for his status this week.

Wikipedia (Ravens season)

COLLEGE FOOTBALL

Three 7–0 teams, *one Saturday.*

Tulane won 38–31 in overtime at Charlotte on Friday, Oct. 30, to get back to 4–4. Charlotte fell to 1–7.

Wikipedia (Tulane season)

The AP poll of Oct. 25 has three unbeaten teams, all 7–0, and all three play on Saturday, Oct. 31. No. 6 Utah, in Morgan Scalley's first season, plays at Cincinnati (5–2) at 3:45 p.m. ET on ESPN, a week after beating the Houston Cougars 21–13. No. 7 UCLA, in Bob Chesney's first season, hosts Nevada (3–4) at the Rose Bowl at 4:15 p.m. ET on the Big Ten Network. No. 1 Miami,

Wikipedia (FBS rankings) · Wikipedia (Utah season) · Wikipedia (UCLA season) · Wikipedia (Miami season)

which beat Pittsburgh 52–23 last week, plays at North Carolina at 7:30 p.m. ET on ABC. Those are scheduled kickoff times; this issue reports results only through Friday night.

The College Football Playoff selection committee publishes its first rankings on Tuesday, Nov. 3, after Saturday's games.

Wikipedia (FBS rankings)

NEXT ON THE CALENDAR

Games that can change the picture

SAT., OCT. 31	**Thunder at Rockets; Kings at Grizzlies**	Houston's first game after its first loss, against the other team Dallas just beat; Memphis's 5–0 start at home to winless Sacramento. Tip times are not listed in the cited records.
MON., NOV. 2, 8:15 P.M. ET	**Bears at Seahawks**	Chicago, 5–2, at Lumen Field, on ESPN.
TUE., NOV. 3	**First CFP rankings**	The committee's first ranking of the season.
FRI., NOV. 6	**Grizzlies vs. Thunder**	Memphis's first NBA Cup game, in West Group B.

Go to the record

2026 NBA Cup All six groups, the opening-night results and the knockout dates.	en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2026_NBA_Cup
2026 Minnesota Vikings season Every score of the 6–0 start, game by game.	en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2026_Minnesota_Vikings_season
2026 NCAA Division I FBS football rankings The AP and coaches' polls, and the CFP ranking dates.	en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2026_NCAA_Division_I_FBS_football_rankings

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